
Professional Goal Assignment

Question 1: Briefly state your professional goal for the semester alongside the metric you planned to use to assess your progress.

My professional goal was to work towards building expertise in this topic via the creation and maintenance of a knowledge log. This log would contain all of the information related to the project. I would measure my success at this metric by tracking how much it grew, and how well I was able to speak about the project and topic at hand. Slip ups in communication would be tracked as well.

Question 2: Please summarize your work on your goal throughout the semester.

I did a lot to work on this goal. Early on I organized our project repo to have an organized docs directory. It contained the general knowledge log, a glossary of terms, a directory for writeups and also a detailed sub-directory that gave links and explanations for every single source used in the project. The log itself functioned mostly as a journal for me to write down my thoughts and current understanding of the topic. I didn't update it as regularly as I would have liked, but I kept at it for a long time and by halfway into the semester this directory was an invaluable source of information for me. The last update to the "knowledge log" really was around March 8th. I stopped adding sources and entries into the log at that time.

Question 3: Did you choose a meaningful goal?

I think so, yes. I constantly struggle with lacking confidence in my knowledge on topics. This helped a lot and with how many twists and turns this project took keeping all my sources organized at a minimum was amazing. Keeping all of my notes, writeups, sources and screenshots in one place gave me a very useful network of information to build from. And though I stopped updating my sources I kept referring back to them as the project progressed all the way up until the end.

Question 4: How did you actively work on your goal throughout the semester?

There's not a ton to explain here really. I read a lot of stuff. I read news articles, federal highway administration guides, state level traffic analysis, anything I could find. And when I found a new source and it seemed useful I would add it to the sources folder. And I'd try at least once a week to update my thoughts on things in the knowledge log, especially during the initial exploratory phase of the project.

I genuinely feel this approach was solid. I couldn't maintain it the whole semester, but it was amazing when it was going.

Question 5: What obstacles or inertia did you encounter in your goal work this semester?

Mental health more than anything. A mix of anxiety from work and the very abstract open ended nature of this project successfully ate away at me enough to lose momentum and consistency on updating my logs. Kinda just gave up I guess. What I've learned is that I should have added something, even if it was brief. I need to be more loose with that kinda thing. Add stuff when I can even when there are huge gaps in time. Stuff happens, but get back on the horse anyway.

Question 6: Did you use your metric-

Cutting the question off here. No, I didn't. The metric was kind of slapped on there to begin with. I'm really not sure how to go into more detail on this. I think putting more time into quantifying this goal would've distracted me from the actual project itself. If I was to re-do this semester I'd still end up ignoring the metric.

Question 7: What did you learn about yourself?

That I really like taking notes and organizing information. I already knew that but man collecting more and more interesting articles and pdfs was really enjoyable. I loved summarizing them and explaining why I was adding them to the log. I was also **reminded** that I struggle a lot when I lose momentum. One brief period of not updating the logs? Never happened again. I gotta be kinder to myself and get back to it.

Question 8: What is one concrete action/habit you can do to improve your professional growth?

As I keep saying, to take the tiny little wins when they're there. The system I had was good, but I have to make an effort to write out my thoughts even if they're brief. Maybe a weekly alert to write down my thoughts every Friday to re-center myself?

Question 9: What is one concrete thing you can do to keep yourself more engaged?

I don't think I struggled here at all. This goal was very easy to motivate myself towards. I like reading. I just need a better system for balancing it out with the actual project work so I don't just stop doing it when work gets busier.

Question 10: Long question not writing it.

A 10, easily. We already have dedicated professional development time given to us per week. We are expected to take it and learn new things. Our team has a culture where if you need to slow down and dive into something more everyone supports it. I actually just did this even. I told my boss I realized I had a passion for data engineering and data validation work, and I'm taking finals week to learn more about some specific topics and how we can improve our project with them. Over the summer I'll be taking time every week to learn more about this stuff too.